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WORLD CUP 2011

The 2011 World Cup was jointly hosted by India, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh and we launched our campaign against Bangladesh in the very first game of the competition on 19 February in Dhaka. As we knew only too well, having lost to them in the 2007 World Cup in the Caribbean, Bangladesh can be a dangerous one-day side and at the Shere Bangla National Stadium in Mirpur they had raucous crowd support.

The general excitement was the first thing that struck us when we arrived in Bangladesh. Every time we went for practice there were close to 30,000 people outside the ground waiting to catch a glimpse of the cricketers. Most of them didn't have tickets for the game, but they were happy just to be there singing, dancing and enjoying the moment. The passionate and enthusiastic Dhaka crowd undoubtedly added a unique dimension to the tournament.

We were feeling confident after winning both of our warm-up games against Australia and New Zealand in Chennai and we all knew this was our best chance to win cricket's ultimate prize. The whole country was behind the team during the competition – in fact, for a month and a half it seemed that all that mattered in India was how we fared in the World Cup. However, we needed to remain calm, and Gary, Paddy Upton, Mike Horn – the well-known explorer who was with us for most of the World Cup and shared stories of his adventures – and the support staff did a wonderful job of keeping our minds on the task at hand.

In Dhaka I invited Yuvraj Singh to my room to have dinner. I have always enjoyed a special friendship with Yuvi and believed that he had a key role to play in the tournament. Yuvi was a little down at the time, as